Reading · Part 5 — Falcons and the Art of Falconry

Multilevel · Questions 30–35

Falcons have existed on Earth for more than 8 million years. They belong to a group of birds called “birds of prey” or raptors, which means they hunt other animals for food. These birds are famous for their sharp eyesight, hooked beaks and incredible flying abilities. Since ancient times, humans have admired falcons not only for their hunting skills but also for their beauty and intelligence. In many cultures, especially in the Middle East, falcons are considered symbols of strength, courage and nobility.

The tradition of training falcons, known as falconry, dates back thousands of years. Egyptian pharaohs, Mongol warriors and Arabian princes all kept falcons as hunting companions and loyal birds. Even today, falconry remains a respected practice and a unique way to connect with nature.

There are more than 40 species of falcons in the world, but a few are especially well known in falconry. The peregrine falcon is the fastest animal on Earth: it can dive at a speed of over 300 kilometres per hour to catch its prey. The saker falcon, common in Central Asia and the Arabian Peninsula, is prized for its boldness, size and hunting instinct. It is especially popular in traditional falconry and is often seen in royal competitions. The gyrfalcon, found in Arctic regions, is the largest falcon and is admired for its snowy white feathers and calm nature. The lanner falcon, with its elegant wings and sharp focus, is often chosen by beginner falconers for training.

Each of these falcons has a special character. For example, the saker is known to be very loyal once trust is built, while the peregrine is more independent and requires an experienced handler. Therefore, choosing the right falcon depends on the goals, preferences and experience level of the falconer. When selecting a falcon, several factors need to be considered: the bird’s age, health, temperament and previous experience. Younger birds may be easier to train but can also be more unpredictable. Older falcons might already have hunting skills but could take longer to trust a new trainer.

Once chosen, a falcon requires daily attention and care. Its diet plays a major role in its strength and performance. In the wild, falcons eat small animals such as mice, rabbits and birds. In captivity, falconers usually feed them fresh meat such as quail, pigeon or rabbit. High-quality food is essential, as a poor diet can affect the bird’s health and flying ability. Clean water, a quiet shelter and daily exercise are also part of a falcon’s routine.

Before a falcon can be used for hunting or flying in public, it must go through manning. Manning is the process of taming a falcon and helping it become comfortable with humans, sounds and the world around it. This is not a quick or easy task. The bird may be nervous, aggressive or simply afraid at first. The process begins with the falconer sitting calmly with the bird perched on a thick glove. This can last for hours, sometimes in complete silence. The goal is to teach the bird that the human is not a threat. Over time, the falcon learns to accept hand-feeding, stay calm around noise and respond to the falconer’s call. Some falcons adjust quickly, while others may take weeks or even months.

Today, falconry is still practised in many parts of the world, including Europe, Central Asia and the Middle East. In countries like the UAE and Saudi Arabia, falconry is considered a national tradition, and falcons are even given passports to travel with their owners.

Questions 30–33

Fill in the missing information. Write NO MORE THAN ONE WORD and / or A NUMBER.

One ancient practice involving falcons is called (30) _____, and it has been passed down through generations in many cultures. The (31) _____ falcon is particularly valued for its physical build and natural hunting behaviour. In captivity, falconers usually feed falcons fresh (32) _____ such as quail, pigeon or rabbit. The process of taming a new falcon and teaching it to trust humans is known as (33) _____.

Questions 34–35

Choose the correct answer A, B, C or D.

34. According to the text, which falcon is especially suited for beginners?

A) Saker falcon

B) Lanner falcon

C) Peregrine falcon

D) Gyrfalcon

35. Why do countries like the UAE give passports to falcons?

A) Because they are recognised as essential pest controllers.

B) Because they must follow strict international breeding laws.

C) Because falconry is regarded as a valuable national tradition.

D) Because they need extra protection from airport authorities.

Sardor Usmonov
Telegram: @EnglishwithUsmonov · ☎ +998 90 897 97 72
https://su126225-afk.github.io/Multilevelstar/

Answer key

30-falconry 31-saker 32-meat 33-manning 34-B 35-C

Sardor Usmonov
Telegram: @EnglishwithUsmonov · ☎ +998 90 897 97 72
https://su126225-afk.github.io/Multilevelstar/